

Your guide to a successful
IN-PERSON BOOK FAIR

We love helping schools bring our book fair to their communities. As a book fair administrator, you will be putting quality books and merchandise into the hands of the kids in your community. Best of all, you will strengthen their faith at the same time.

My name is **Loupio** and I am going to be your guide to this guide. You probably recognize me from my comic book series, *The Adventures of Loupio*. And now I'm the mascot for Ignatius Book Fairs! I'm going to show you what you need to do to make **YOUR** book fair successful. So, follow my lead and let's get started!



STEP ONE



Choose the best company to provide everything you need to host a successful book fair — one that will support you every step of the way!

You've accomplished STEP ONE already. You have your dates set so read on to see how we can maximize your fair! Throughout this guide, you will find links in Orange to our beautiful **RESOURCES**, so make sure you click the links and check them out.

STEP TWO



Design Your Own Book Fair Experience.

As you prepare your fair, here are key practices that have worked well for us in running our own successful fairs.

1. Your community needs advance notice of the book fair schedule to plan their visit. Make sure to advertise often before, during and as your fair is getting ready to close.

QUICK TIP FOR COMMUNITY OUTREACH: A flyer should be shared the week before your Ignatius book fair opens letting your community know the opportunities for book purchases. Use [THIS LINK](#) to edit the backpack flyer with your organization's unique schedule.

2. We recommend keeping your book fair open one or more evenings and/or over the weekend. Consider hosting an evening event where families can shop, enjoy a snack or beverage, and socialize. You may also want to stay open throughout the weekend, especially around your Mass schedule. Think beyond your school community when advertising. Reach families who attend other parishes, non-religious schools, or homeschool. Be creative with your events and outreach to connect with as many families in your community as possible.



STEP THREE



Create an online sign-up for volunteers.

Free services like [SIGN-UP GENIUS](#) work well. Ignatius Book Fairs will send nearly everything you'll need, except volunteers. So be sure to recruit help to make the lifting lighter! Volunteers can help you:

- Develop fun ideas to promote the fair within the community
- Empty boxes and set up the fair
- Scan in boxes before the fair begins
- Bring in music to keep the space lively
- Clear and decorate the space
- Work the floor, suggesting books to children and parents
- Organize refreshments and treats for evening and weekend events
- Run a craft table to keep children occupied while parents shop
- Promote the fair on social media and in other outlets
- Run the check-out station
- Pack up and clean up

STEP FOUR



Determine the best room set-up for ease of browsing and sales.

We recommend that you arrange the tables away from the walls and set up in a space of at least 800 square feet.

We recommend you have 12-16 six-foot tables, or the equivalent, available for books and other items. The books will arrive sorted by category. Here's an example of how you might arrange your tables. (Smaller schools will use the smaller number of tables while larger schools will use the larger number.)

Early Reader: 1 table

Picture Books: 2-3 tables

Elementary books: 3 tables

Middle School books: 1-3 tables

Seasonal books: 1 table

Crafts and activities: 1 table

Comic Books: 1 table

Teens and Beyond (13+) 1 table

Toys and Trinkets: 1 table

Check-out station: 1-2 tables

If you are hosting events during your fair, you may need additional tables for snacks and beverages or spaces to entertain younger children while parents shop — for example, a table with **COLORING PAGES** pages and crayons.

As part of your set up box you will be receiving colorful tablecloths, table-top book stands, table category signs, and 5 posters to use as décor. These will arrive at the same time as your books.

Things you may need to supply: bags for purchases, a cashbox for cash sales, a sharpie marker, packing tape.

Join us for a live 3-part online workshop series for help with all aspects of hosting an amazing fair for your community.



STEP FIVE

☐ **Make sure the book fair details (times/dates/location) are on all necessary calendars including the school and parish calendar.**

Use our **ADVERTISING RESOURCES** for help with graphics.



STEP SIX

☐ **Use social media and other marketing ideas to get the word out early and often.**

In order for your community to know about the fair dates, times and location, you will need to advertise early, before the fair, and daily during the fair. We recommend sending a Save-the-Date announcement 4-6 weeks before the fair and then advertising it weekly leading up to opening day. Use our graphics for your newsletters, or in your social media posts: **ADVERTISING RESOURCES**. During the fair, post pictures of what the fair looks like and what's available. Before the last sales day, remind your community of their last opportunity to shop and support your school by stopping by the fair.

Ideas for where to advertise to get the word out:

- Parish bulletin
- Parish Calendar
- Parish email list
- Announcement from the pulpit

- Invitation to local parishes in the same diocese.
- School newsletter from the principal or book fair coordinator if you are associated with a school
- School paper
- School and parish websites, Facebook pages, Instagram account, X
- Library Flyers
- Announcements to Homeschoolers, Co-ops and other area schools
- Classroom or teacher newsletter



STEP SEVEN



Join our live workshop.

Watch for email invitations to our 3-part live workshop series featuring task-specific topics to keep you on pace as you plan your fair. We encourage you to invite your volunteer team to join. Part 1 takes place within 90 days of your fair, Part 2 happens around 60 days out, and the final workshop occurs during the month leading up to your event. Even if you cannot join us live, please do RSVP yes for the workshops so that you can receive the recordings.



STEP EIGHT



Determine how you will decorate your fair.

It's important that your fair looks beautiful, fun and inviting. You will be receiving all of the basics to make your fair look great. Anything you do on top of what we provide is going to be a bonus for your community.

One to two weeks before your fair begins, we will deliver:

- All the books and items for sale plus 2 payment devices
- Table category signs in clear acrylic frames or enclosed in an envelope
- 50 to 75 book stands
- Rectangular tablecloths in the colors of mint, yellow, and orange.
- 5 decorative posters

The rest is up to you! Think of seasonal themes, book themes, art from your younger students, anything to make it uniquely yours.

STEP NINE



Get ready for delivery!

One to two weeks before your book fair begins, Ignatius Book Fairs will deliver your books and other materials. Depending on the size of your organization, you will receive 20-38 boxes.

Books will be sorted and packaged into boxes according to the categories corresponding to the table signs: Picture Books, Early Readers, Comic Books, Elementary Books, Middle School Books, Crafts and Activities, Teens and Beyond (13+), Seasonal Selections, as well as Toys and Trinkets. The category is listed on the packing slip (the 4x6 label attached to the outside of each box). This is the same label you will use to scan in your inventory.

Follow these steps for a quick and easy set up:

1. Find the box marked **Open First**. This will contain your payment devices. Plug them in to charge them fully.
2. Find the Set Up Box. Set up your tables, put the tablecloths on, set the category signs where you'd like those books to be set up, and put 2-3 book stands on each table. T
3. Charge your payment device. Connect it to WiFi first, then log in using your unique code.
4. Begin to scan in the boxes. This will load your payment devices with the inventory you received.
5. Sort your boxes and place them in front of the tables where those book categories will be set up.
6. Unbox the books and arrange them on the tables. Have fun with this process. Remember to arrange the books for maximum viewing possibilities – bring the tables away from the walls and make sure the titles can be seen from each side of the table.

For instructions on how to use the features on the Point-of-Sale devices, click [HERE](#).

What to keep in mind: Advertising early and often is essential and is the #1 way to earn more rewards for your school, and to have a fun and positive experience!

These tips will help make your fair more successful:

1. Within 14 days of your fair: Email a letter home to your families explaining the dates/times and purpose of the book fair.
2. Within 7 days of your fair: Email a link to our [general flyer](#) and a [sneak peek flyer](#) so families can start to preview what will be offered.
3. Ensure that your fair schedule allows your community ample time to come in, look around, and make some fantastic choices!
4. Share on your social media channels. Follow the sample advertising schedule below.
5. Allow the children time to preview the fair and create a wish list to bring home

6 weeks before the fair

Use this graphic: [SAVE THE DATE FOR OUR BOOK FAIR](#) to make a social media post on all of your social media channels, put a post in the parish bulletin, and include the information in your weekly newsletter, email, or on the bulletin board.

Sample wording: We are excited to announce that we are hosting an Ignatius Book Fair on: (include start and end dates of fair). Ignatius Book Fairs offers a variety of beautiful, fun, engaging books and activities that will be your children's favorites. Supporting the book fair with a purchase will help us purchase new books for our library and classrooms. Please mark the dates down! Online shopping is available too! Be sure to choose our school from the drop-down menu so your purchase counts towards rewards for (Your School Name) Free shipping to our office is available during the dates of the fair. Free shipping (in the contiguous US) is available when your item total is over \$25.

5 weeks before the fair

Share [THIS VIDEO](#) on social media and include the link in a newsletter or email to parents.

Sample wording to accompany the video: Our book fair is in 5 weeks! We are excited to be partnering with Ignatius Book Fairs! Click [HERE](#) to create an account and link to our school so that (Your School) receives benefits from your purchases.



How do I create a parent account and connect your school?

4 weeks before the fair

Post another save the date informational post.

Use [THIS GRAPHIC](#) to remind your community about the dates of the book fair.



3 weeks before the fair

Select a few titles from the website that you, your staff, or your teachers are reading and let your community know these books are available in person or on our website. Explain how all sales will benefit your organization.

2 weeks before the fair

Have the principal send an invitation to the community, letting them know of the opportunities to shop in person during the fair.

1 week before the fair

Find the marketing materials that arrived with your books and put some Sneak Peak flyers out in common areas, or post inside your school newsletter to remind families that the fair is almost here, and what they can expect to see during the fair.

The evening before the fair

Use [THIS GRAPHIC](#) to post on social media.



First day of the fair

Kick off the first day of your book fair by introducing the [READING CHALLENGE](#) to your families.

Second day of the book fair

Use **THIS GRAPHIC** to post on social media.

Sample wording: We are on day 2 of our book fair. Shopping is available in-person at these times [TIMES], in this location [LOCATION]. All purchases help us with our goal of getting new books for our classrooms and library. Free shipping to our school is available during the fair dates for those who prefer to shop online. Use **THIS LINK** to place your order. When creating your account, be sure to select our school as the one you'd like to support.

3rd day of the book fair

Social media post: Have you checked out our book fair? If you're unsure what books might be a good fit for your children or yourself, reading recommendations by age and grade level are available both on-site and online.

4th day of the book fair

Social media post: Highlight five books that are currently popular at the fair. Use the point-of-sale device to identify strong-selling titles, or, if POS data isn't available, use your best judgment based on what you've observed selling well. Frame the post around these being some of the community's most popular picks so far. Use a photo from the fair showing the featured books together, ideally on display or being browsed by customers. If a group photo isn't possible, create a simple collage of the five book covers.

5th day of the book fair

Social media post: Encourage families to create a simple daily "Stop, Drop & Read" routine. Share a few easy ways to make it work—everyone reads independently in the same room, parents read aloud to their children, or the family reads a few pages of a book or daily devotion together. Photo: Use a photo of the picture book section of the fair, showing the variety of books families can choose from.

6th day of the book fair

Social media post: On the final day of the fair, thank families for stopping by and supporting the book fair through their purchases. Invite parents to share the titles they selected or recommend for other families. Ideally, have the volunteer team comment with a few of their own favorite purchases or picks to help spark ideas.

Sample wording: "Tomorrow is the last day of our book fair! Thank you to everyone who has stopped by and supported our school. We'd love to know—which books did your family pick out? Share your favorites below to help other families find their next great read!"

7th day of the book fair

Remind families that today is the final day of the book fair and highlight that the school is close to reaching its goal for earning free books for the library and classrooms. Briefly explain that purchases generate a percentage of net sales that the school can use toward free books. End with a warm thank-you and a note about how much fun it has been seeing families discover new favorites and classics.



FINAL STEP



Have a wonderful Ignatius Book Fair!

Please reach out to your Book Fair Manager should any issue arise. We are here to cheer you on and give you advice and support along the way!